A Yatra in India’s Eternal Yatra

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The evening of 7 September 2022 was extremely memorable for me, because that is when I reached Kanyakumari for the Bharat Jodo Yatra. Kanyakumari is the confluence of three seas. The inaugural function was taking place on its sandy shores. As the day progressed, the ocean waves were shaking the coastline portending what was to come. The roar of the ocean echoed in our ears. As the waves of the sea were crashing on the rocks rhythmically, a question kept colliding with the rocks in my mind. I kept asking myself: What is ‘India’? Who is ‘India’? In one sense, India has a geographical existence. Several million years ago, due to geological changes, a part of India collided with Eurasia. This collision gave shape to the Himalayas. It is the sentinel and symbol of our cultural journey.

Those waves that arose from the ocean also kept knocking on my psyche, saying that India is not just a geographical entity, but also a confluence of diverse cultures and countless migratory human groups. The genes of the first human group that came from Africa about 65,000 years ago are more or less present in every Indian today. Later, groups came from the grasslands of Iran, Central Asia and South East Asia, contributing to the rich tapestry of India.

India is the accumulation of thousands of years of experiences, natural understanding and wisdom. India is an eternal yatra. Like every yatri, holding on to the past while moving forward. It neither remains lost in the past nor becomes detached from it. It is nurturing the heritage, advancing towards the future without being bound by the past. One cannot move forward by looking backwards. Nor can one escape by hiding from it. This